

Summary Writing V/s Precis Writing

Similarities between Precis and Summary

1. Written in Past tense
2. Supply title.
3. A complete self-contained document
4. Written in III Person...
5. Only indirect speech is used.

Difference between Summary and Precis

Summary is written in own words while as Precis includes key words from the original passage and goes paragraph wise.

Summary is written in one paragraph while as Precis can be written in multiple paragraph

Summary writing requires a 'close reading' of a given passage. It means, "Writing a summary" of a given passage. It is an exercise in compression, cutting all the unnecessary repetitive details and expressing the central idea.

Usually written in one-third word of the given material.

She presented a research paper indeed in the conference held last year. It was original paper, no doubt about it. The panel did took notice of her title as she was the only one to speak on 'women's rights in the third world'

She presented a research paper on 'Women's right in the third world' in a conference last year.

Why this exercise is important?

- To write summary, one has to read closely.
- It improves comprehension and retention of information.

- Summarizing any given passage makes a reader read the passage with close attention
- It improves writing compositions or any creative writing. A person gets trained to think and place one's thought in logical sequence, choose the important and key points worth highlighting from digressions, loose diffuse thinking and muddled expression. This organization

Example

- ✓ He served this organization for ten years without taking even a single penny from them.
- ✓ He worked as a **volunteer** in this organization for a **decade**.

- It trains the mind to express your idea in a fixed number of words containing the main theme
- Practically, one gets trained to grasp the matter / situation quickly in practical life and reproduce it clearly and concisely.

Some rules to be followed are:

1. Summary should be written in your own words.
 2. It should be complete and self-contained.
 3. All redundancies should be strictly avoided.
 4. Use idioms, one word substitutes, and indirect speech to compress a passage.
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- ✓ I have a habit of delaying things unnecessarily. I push things and try to find excuses till the deadline stares right on my face and I am left with no other option. Though I try as much to work on it but it is hard to overcome
 - ✓ **Procrastination** is a problem with me and I am working to overcome it.
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5. It is not same as 'paraphrasing'. In paraphrasing, same content is written in own words. A paraphrased article could be longer or same in length than the original paragraph but precis is always smaller or one-third in length.
 6. Summary expresses only the main theme.
 7. Supply a title to summary once the main idea or subject is clear

8. Look for the key sentence/topical sentence. Usually, it appears in starting or towards the end.
9. Align the information with the main theme. That will help in separating important information from repetition, digressions and irrelevant writings.
10. Once central idea is clear, supply main heading, mention the subject, briefly make notes

Example I

A mother works from morning till night to satisfy the needs of her husband and children. But sadly, she gets no reward or praise for her labours. They don't ever think that the mother is not a machine. They never realize that she, too is a human being and needs rest. Mrs. Pearson is very fond of her husband and children. But they are very thoughtless and selfish. The children take no notice of the mother. They treat her like a servant. Mrs. Pearson's neighbour, Mrs. Fitzgerald offers to set Pearson family right. She knows some magic. Mrs. Fitzgerald changes her personality with that of Mrs. Pearson. Soon Mrs. Pearson's daughter Doris, comes home from work. She feels shocked to see her mother smoking (actually, she is Mrs. Fitzgerald). Doris asks her mother for tea but Mrs. Pearson tells her to make it herself. Mother tells Doris bluntly to do the ironing herself. She mocks at her boyfriend also. She calls him half-witted. Doris can't tolerate all this. She runs out in tears. Next Cyril comes in. He is annoyed to see that Mother has prepared no tea for him. She has not mended his shirt also.

“Mother's Day” by John Boynton Priestley (13 Sep. 1894 – 14 Aug. 1984)

Summary: (Life and Magic/ Story of Mrs. Pearson)

The play portrays life of a mother with grown up children. The insensitivity and ingratitude of children and husband towards Mrs. Pearson are the highlights of play till her neighbour Mrs. Fitzgerald decides to teach them a lesson. By her magical power, Mrs. Fitzgerald and Mrs. Pearson exchange their positions and set things right in the household.

Example II

Chitrangada was a girl but raised as a boy but never lived like a woman. she was strong and bold as a warrior. One day she saw **Arjuna** in a forest on the bank of the *Purna* River while hunting. *Chitra* falls for *Arjuna*, the moment she saw him. She visits lord **Madana** and **Vasanta** and asks them to give her perfect beauty for a day so that she can win over *Arjuna*. Impressed with her plea, they turn her into a beautiful woman, not just for a day but a year.

The next scene is *Chitra*, enters embracing her marvellous beauty. *Arjuna* immediately tries to have a conversation with her. *Chitra* said that she has been looking for the man of her desire. After several talks, *Arjuna* said that he would break his vow of celibacy for her. However *Chitra* was not glad to see that he has been falling for her outer beauty instead of her real self. Later she admits to *Madana* and *Vasanta* that she is not being true to herself. The two gods advise her to be with *Arjuna* for a year. She does as told but the idea of *Arjuna* leaving her after the spell will worries her. Moreover, *Chitra* has never told him her real name.

Summary: Chitra and Arjun

Warrior Princess Chitra falls in love with prince Arjuna. She takes help of God Vasant and Madan to become the most beautiful woman and succeeds in winning over her man of desires. Though fear of losing him continues to haunt her once the spell was over.

Example III

In *The Canterbury Tales*, Chaucer is not an innocent narrator as although on the surface it appears that he is talking about an extremely pious woman in The Prioress Tale, i.e., Madam Eglantine. He has highlighted the age-old hypocrisy that is observed among the clergy and the priest class in all religions of the world. There is an air of fakery and ornamentation that surrounds them.

They themselves cannot be described as the “people of the Book” in the true sense but impose their beliefs on others. The Prioress is trying to be fastidious to an extent. The prioress was not that well-versed in French compared to the native speaker, but tried to portray herself as one. Her conduct tells us that she is trying

to abide to the standards of royal courts. Chaucer writes, “She wolde weepe if that she saw a mous, caught in a trappe, if it were deed or bledde”.

The poet first creates an image in our minds, of a typical Disney princess who can't even stand the sight of violence that is a common part of the natural food cycle, but later tells us that she has no problem feeding meat to her dogs. Thus, again highlighting her dubious character. One would think as an Indian that Prioress, built would be similar to that of a faqir or a sanyasi, but the reality is that she is overweight and does not look like a person who eats only bare minimum required amount of calories.